

CORE FORMULA

Shrink the scope: ask for one part, not the whole. -> Name the exact action: say precisely what you want done. -> Make the boundary honest: state what you are not asking for. -> Accept yes or no cleanly: leave the choice genuinely open. -> Example: "Could you look at just the first paragraph and tell me if the tone lands? No need to edit the rest."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one small, concrete part of what you need and ask for only that: "Could you do just X?"

BEST FOR

- Busy people who cannot take on a large request
- First steps in a new or uncertain relationship
- Restarting a stalled project or conversation
- Reducing someone's sense of overwhelm
- Moving from good intentions to a concrete action
- Getting a fast, low-cost yes to build momentum

PHRASE BANK

Quick asks · One-line starters

- "Could you do just this one part?"
- "Can I ask for one small thing?"
- "Just the first step for now?"
- "Could you give me one example?"
- "Would five minutes work?"
- "Can we sort only the next bit today?"
- "A quick yes or no is completely fine."

Warm and social · Friends and family

- "No rush, but could you do just the one thing when you get a sec?"
- "Would you mind casting an eye over only the first bit?"
- "It's only a tiny favour, if you're up for it."
- "Could you help me with just the start? I'll take it from there."
- "Even five minutes would mean a lot."
- "Only if it's easy — could you send me the one name?"

Work and meetings · Colleagues and clients

- "Could we decide only the next step in this meeting?"
- "Would you review just the summary, not the full document?"
- "Can I get your call on one thing before we go wider?"
- "Could you approve the first milestone, and we'll scope the rest later?"
- "I need a decision on this single point today, nothing else."
- "Could you spend five minutes on the opening and tell me if it lands?"
- "Just the headline figure for now would unblock me."

Naming the exact action · Concrete and specific

- "Could you look at just the first paragraph?"
- "Could you give me one example, not the whole answer?"

- "Could you send me the name, not the full introduction yet?"
- "I'm asking for one edit, not a rewrite."
- "Could you reply to just this one question?"
- "The whole ask is: read one page and tell me if the tone's off."
- "All I need is a yes or no on the date."

Softening and stepping back · Release the pressure

- "No pressure at all — only if you have the time."
- "Feel free to say no; it won't be a problem."
- "If that's too much, even a pointer would help."
- "Let me make that smaller: could you just do the first part?"
- "Ignore the rest — one thing is all I need."
- "We can leave it and come back another time."

Guarded or high-status · Optional and low-cost

- "Would it be useful if I checked the premise before I respond?"
- "I'll take the smallest slice of your time — just one question?"
- "If it helps, I can narrow this to a single decision."
- "I'll keep this to one ask so it's easy to weigh up."
- "Only the part that needs your call — nothing more."
- "Would a two-minute version be easier than the full thing?"

Digital and text · One clean sentence

- "To make sure I answer the right thing: is it the date you need?"
- "Quick one — could you confirm just the date?"
- "One small ask: can you send the file, not the summary?"
- "Short version — yes or no on the first option?"
- "Just checking the one point before I reply properly: is X right?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Can you help me with this whole thing?
Better: Could you look at just the first paragraph?
Best: Could you look at just the first paragraph and tell me whether the tone feels too formal? No need to edit the rest.
- Weak: Can we go through the whole plan at some point?
Better: Could we decide the next step today?
Best: Could we decide only the next step today, and park the rest for our next catch-up?
- Weak: Could you introduce me to your network?
Better: Could you send me one name to start with?
Best: Could you send me just the one name you think is most relevant? I'll handle the intro myself.

DECISION TREE

If They are still mid-thought

Wait — don't drop the ask into the middle of what they're saying.

If The ask still feels big or vague

Shrink it to one concrete action before you say it.

"Could you do just the first part?"

If They seem hesitant or resistant

Name the concern and make the ask optional before repeating it.

"No pressure — only if it's easy."

If They accept and the exchange feels easier

Continue and build on the small yes rather than piling on.

"Thank you — that's exactly enough."

If They tense up or the ease drops

Repair or release the ask rather than pushing.

"Let me make that smaller, or we can leave it for now."

If You're tempted to expand the ask after a yes

Stop — keep the boundary you named honest.

"That's all I needed for today."

SCENARIOS

Social conversation

Keep it warm and brief; ask for one small thing. — "Could you help me with just the start? I'll take it from there."

Professional discussion

Name the single action or decision clearly. — "Could we decide only the next step in this meeting?"

Digital message

Write one clean sentence; don't overexplain. — "Quick one — could you confirm just the date?"

Conflict or objection

Validate or summarise before you make the ask. — "I hear the concern. Could we agree just the one next step?"

High-status or guarded person

Make the ask optional and low-cost. — "Would a two-minute version be easier than the full thing?"

Close relationship

Drop the technique feel and use ordinary language. — "Could you just grab the one thing while you're up?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The real ask is large and deserves to be named honestly
- The person needs full context to give genuine consent
- A clean request or low-friction ask would be more transparent
- Shrinking the ask would create false agreement or hidden pressure
- The move would add exposure, embarrassment, or a sense of being managed
- Physical safety or an emergency needs a direct, complete request now

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the oversized ask

Notice three times today when a request (yours or someone else's) was bigger or vaguer than it needed to be. Write down the smaller, concrete version each time.

Day 2 — Say the minimum move aloud

Take one real request and shrink it to a single line — "Could you do just X?" Say it aloud three times until it stops sounding scripted.

Day 3 — Add the honest boundary

Rewrite three asks using the full formula: shrink the scope, name the exact action, and state clearly what you are not asking for.

Day 4 — Practise the recovery

In a low-stakes chat, deliberately over-ask, then use one recovery line to make it smaller: "Let me put that more simply — just the one thing."

Day 5 — Field test, low stakes

Use one small ask in a real conversation and note the calibration cue — did they relax and act, or tense up? Adjust once on the spot.

Day 6 — Field test, higher stakes

Use a small ask with a busy or higher-status person. Keep it to one optional, concrete action and let the yes or no stand cleanly.

Day 7 — Review and set a rule

Look back at the week. Which asks shrank cleanly? Where were you tempted to bait-and-switch? Write one honesty rule for yourself.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice the cue and shrink the ask before speaking?
- Was the ask one concrete action, not a vague or large one?
- Was the boundary honest — did I say what I was not asking for?
- Did I leave a genuine yes or no, without pressure?
- Did I watch their response and adjust?
- Did I repair quickly if it missed, rather than pushing?